

Weighing, Not Balancing

Lesson 4 — Evaluating an argument

What you will know and be able to do

- 1 Explain the difference between genuine evaluation and artificial fifty-fifty balance
- 2 Weigh multiple factors against each other using explicit, stated criteria
- 3 Reach a real judgement even when the evidence is genuinely mixed
- 4 Avoid the trap of listing factors without ever actually ranking them

Structure and historiography are not enough alone

Lessons 2 and 3 built a well-organised essay engaging with real historians. This lesson adds the skill that actually earns the top mark band: genuinely evaluating, rather than simply describing, competing explanations.

‘Balanced’ does not mean ‘fifty-fifty’

Many students believe a balanced essay must conclude that all factors mattered roughly equally. This is a misreading of what balance means. A genuinely balanced essay considers multiple factors fairly, and then reaches a clear, reasoned judgement about which mattered most — even if that judgement is that one factor was overwhelmingly dominant.

Weighing by what standard, exactly?

“Factor A mattered more than Factor B” is an assertion, not an evaluation, unless you state why: Was Factor A a necessary condition, without which the outcome could not have happened? Did it operate over a longer timescale? Did it affect more people, or shape the outcome more decisively? Naming your criterion is what turns a claim into an argument.

Weighing causes of the 1962 Algerian independence

Algeria's independence resulted from armed insurgency, French domestic political exhaustion, and shifting international opinion. A genuine evaluation might argue: the war's brutality made continued French rule domestically unsustainable — a necessary condition without which international pressure alone would likely have been ignored, as it had been in comparable cases. That is a specific, defensible ranking, not a vague list.

A real judgement can still be a qualified one

Sometimes the fairest judgement is not “A mattered most” but “A and B were of comparable importance, but for different reasons and at different stages.” This is still a genuine evaluation, provided you explain the difference in kind between the two factors' contributions, rather than simply refusing to choose.

Refusing to judge is not sophistication

“It is impossible to say which factor was most important”, offered as a conclusion without further reasoning, reads as an evasion rather than a nuanced judgement. If you genuinely believe factors are inseparable, explain specifically why — for instance, that one factor only became significant because of the other — rather than simply declining to answer.

Evaluate, don't just list

For the claim 'Economic weakness, more than military defeat, explains the end of Portuguese colonial rule in Angola.', write a paragraph that genuinely weighs the two factors against each other using an explicit criterion.

- State your criterion for weighing the two factors clearly
- Use specific evidence for both economic weakness and military factors
- Reach a real, specific judgement — not a refusal to choose

Key terms from today

Genuine evaluation

Weighing factors against explicit criteria to reach a real judgement.

Artificial balance

Concluding all factors mattered equally without genuine reasoning.

Necessary condition

A factor without which an outcome could not have occurred.

Qualified judgement

A specific, reasoned verdict that two factors mattered differently, not equally or not at all.

What to remember

Genuine evaluation means weighing factors against an explicit, stated criterion and reaching a real judgement — not concluding that everything mattered equally, and not refusing to choose. Even mixed evidence can support a specific, defensible verdict.

Lesson 5 — Comparing across regional in-depth topics

Next lesson closes Block A: using both our regional in-depth topics together for revision and synthesis, even though the real exam tests them separately.